

Module 8: Understanding Auditing Standards

Key Points on Certification

1. Certification Overview
 - a. Certification is provided by certification bodies, which are accredited by accreditation bodies.
 - b. Certification is open to any organization, regardless of size or sector, with uniform processes and requirements.
2. Role of Certification Auditors
 - a. Certification auditors conduct audits on behalf of the certification body.
 - b. Auditors must:
 - c. Have experience relevant to the type of organization they audit (e.g., construction industry experience for a construction company).
 - d. Be competent in the specific standards (e.g., ISO 9001 for quality management or ISO 22001 for food safety).
 - e. Have training and experience in auditing management systems.
3. Competency Assurance
 - a. Certification bodies are responsible for ensuring their auditors are competent.
 - b. Accreditation bodies audit the certification bodies to verify they maintain effective processes for auditor competency.

Certification Process Overview

Key Elements of the Certification Process

1. Preparation and Implementation
 - c. Organizations begin with an implementation project to meet standard requirements, developing necessary processes and documentation.
2. Choosing a Certification Body
 - d. Organizations select a certification body, which will collect information to determine audit days and develop the audit program.
 - e. An optional gap analysis audit may be offered to identify any initial gaps.
3. Initial Certification Audit
 - a. Conducted in two stages:
 - b. Stage 1: Auditors assess if the organization has a basic framework, processes, and documentation. They report any gaps to be addressed.
 - c. Stage 2: Auditors test the management system's implementation, verify fixes for previous gaps, and confirm the organization meets all requirements.
 - d. Certification Issuance: If standards are met, the certificate is issued, even if there are minor non-conformities, provided the organization commits to improvements.
4. Surveillance Audits

- a. Certificate validity: 3 years, with surveillance audits every 6–12 months.
 - b. Surveillance audits check for system maintenance and continuous improvement.
5. Recertification Audit
- a. After 3 years, if certification is to continue, a recertification audit is conducted (one stage, more in-depth than surveillance).
 - b. Organization must show ongoing management system maintenance and improvements over the three-year period.

Certification of Integrated Management Systems

Key Elements

- 1. Multiple Standards Certification
 - a. Organizations can be certified against multiple ISO standards (e.g., ISO 9001, ISO 14001, ISO 50001).
- 2. Integrated Management System Audit
 - b. A combined audit assesses compliance with multiple standards in a single process.
 - c. Certification auditors ensure that requirements for each standard are met.
- 3. Benefits of Integrated Audits
 - a. Reduced Audit Days: Overlapping requirements allow for fewer audit days compared to separate audits.
 - b. Single Audit Program: The organization only needs to manage one audit schedule, saving time and resources.

Introduction to Accreditation and ISO 17021

Key Points on ISO 17021-2015

- 1. Overview of ISO 17021-2015
 - a. ISO 17021-2015 is the standard certification bodies must meet to gain accreditation from an accreditation body.
 - b. Accreditation bodies are typically independent organizations, often government-regulated, operating at a national level (e.g., UCAS in the UK, ANSI in the US).
- 2. Purpose of Accreditation
 - c. Accreditation enables certification bodies to issue formally recognized management system certificates.
- 3. Accreditation Process
 - d. Involves an audit of the certification body's management systems and witness audits to assess lead auditors' competency and processes.
 - e. The accreditation body audits the certification body's performance, not the client being audited.

4. ISO 17021-1 Requirements
 - a. Covers requirements for all certification body audits, focusing on:
 - b. Audit Principles (Clause 4): Fundamental principles that should guide auditing practices.
 - c. Audit Processes (Clause 9): Detailed procedures that must be followed during audits.
 - d. Annexes provide additional information on auditing competencies and evaluation methods.
5. Certification Body Requirements
 - a. Beyond auditor competencies, ISO 17021-1 outlines requirements related to:
 - b. Issuance of certificates
 - c. Management of confidentiality and conflict of interest
 - d. Handling appeals and complaints
6. Key Auditing Topics
 - a. Audit Principles: Essential for guiding auditing processes.
 - b. Audit Program: Certification bodies must maintain an audit program for each organization.
 - c. Audit Delivery: Established procedures must be followed for conducting audits.
 - d. Auditor Competency: Certification bodies must demonstrate auditors' competency through strict requirements.

Competences of Lead Auditors Required by ISO 17021-1

Key Points

1. Establishment of Competency Processes
 - a. ISO 17021-1:2015 requires certification bodies to develop processes for:
 - b. Setting detailed competency criteria.
 - c. Defining evaluation methods.
 - d. Implementing competency development programs.
2. General Competency Requirements for Auditors (Annex A)

Knowledge Areas:

 - a. Audit principles, practices, and techniques applicable to all management system audits.
 - b. Certification body processes and procedures.
 - c. Specific sector business operations, products, processes, and organizations.
 - d. General business management practices across various business types.
 - e. Skills:
 - f. Presentation, note-taking, and report writing.
 - g. Interviewing techniques.
 - h. Audit management capabilities.
 - i. Proficiency in relevant languages.
3. Additional Competency Requirements
 - a. Other ISO 17021 standards outline further competencies:
 - b. ISO 17021-2: Competencies for auditors of ISO 14001.

- c. ISO 17021-3: Competencies for auditors of ISO 9001.
- 4. Multidisciplinary Audits
 - a. Lead auditors performing multidisciplinary audits must be:
 - b. Competent in at least one management system standard.
 - c. Knowledgeable about the other standards involved in the audit.

Introduction to the International Accreditation Forum (IAF) Documents

Key Points

- 1. What is the IAF?
 - a. The International Accreditation Forum (IAF) is an association of accreditation bodies worldwide.
 - b. Its purpose is to coordinate and harmonize the efforts of different accreditation bodies and organizations involved in conformity assessments.
- 2. Multilateral Recognition Arrangement (MLA)
 - a. Accreditation bodies that sign the IAF MLA agree to recognize each other's accreditations.
 - b. Example: A certification body accredited by the UK Accreditation Service (UCAS) is recognized in Australia without needing separate accreditation from JAS-ANZ.
- 3. IAF Published Documents
 - Mandatory Documents (MDs):
 - a. Used by accreditation bodies during audits of certification bodies.
 - b. Provide guidance on implementing ISO 17021-1 requirements.
 - Cover topics such as:
 - c. Calculating audit duration for certification bodies.
 - d. Developing multi-site audit programs and sampling processes.
 - e. Evaluating audit competencies.
 - f. Guidance Documents (GDs) and Information Documents (IDs):
 - g. Offer additional advice and information, not specific requirements.
 - h. Help certification bodies and lead auditors understand expectations from accreditation bodies.

Introduction to ISO 19011

Key Points

- 1. Purpose of ISO 19011
 - a. ISO 19011 provides guidance for conducting audits of management systems.
 - b. It is optional for organizations undertaking internal audits, even if they are certified to standards like ISO 9001 or ISO 14001.
 - c. Certification against ISO 19011 is not possible; instead, organizations use its guidance to develop internal audit processes.

2. Evolution of ISO 19011
 - a. Initially focused on quality management systems, the standard was revised in 2011 to encompass various management systems, including:
 - b. Health and safety
 - c. Environmental management
 - d. Energy management
 - e. Information security
 - f. Food safety
3. Guidance Provided by ISO 19011
 - a. Offers guidance on:
 - b. Setting up and managing audit programs.
 - c. Planning and delivering audits.
 - d. Evaluating auditor and audit team competency.
4. Application of the Standard
 - a. Applicable to any organization wishing to enhance its management system auditing.
 - b. Supports both single-topic audits (e.g., quality) and integrated management systems, allowing for combined audit programs, procedures, and competency processes.

Principles of Auditing

Key Points

1. Importance of Audit Principles
 - a. Auditors must adhere to fundamental principles to ensure effective audits.
 - b. Ignoring these principles can lead to ineffective audits and poor decision-making by management.
2. Principles Defined by ISO 19011

Integrity:

- a. Auditors must act professionally, honestly, and within legal boundaries.
- b. They should resist pressures to compromise their honesty and use professional judgment to ensure fairness.

Fair Presentation:

- a. Audit conclusions, findings, and reports should accurately reflect the audit results.
- b. Auditors must be balanced and truthful in their reporting.

Due Professional Care:

- a. Auditors are expected to provide informed and professional opinions.
- b. They should strive to deliver the highest quality of professional input during audits.

Confidentiality:

- a. Auditors must treat all client information and data with confidentiality.

- b. This obligation may only be overridden by legal requirements to disclose information.

Independence:

- a. Auditors should remain independent from the organization being audited.
- b. They must avoid any bias or conflicts of interest, disclosing any past dealings with the audit client to the certification body.